body with hot iron.' He went on to ask that if he was killed the government should look after his wife, his two children and his old father in Delhi.

After a few days more of torture, Mohan Lal had sunk into despair and began writing about himself in the third person, as if already beyond help: 'Mohun Lall is severely beaten three times and most disgracefully and cruelly treated. He has been hitherto forced to pay Rs 18,000 and God knows what may befall him more than this. Kindly do something for his release from such pains.'[40] But, without Burnes to protect him, Mohan Lal had no friends in Pollock's camp and received no letters or reassurances from his employers in Jalalabad. The only man to attempt to raise money to ransom him was his old Delhi College schoolfriend and fellow 'intelligencer', Wade's munshi Shahamat Ali, who from Indore attempted to organise an immediate loan from the Hindu bankers of Kabul to effect his release.[41] He eventually achieved this, aided by a belated letter of protest from Pollock addressed to Akbar Khan; but apparently not before Mohan Lal had been forced to convert to Islam.[42]

In the meantime, Akbar Khan had the defences of the Bala Hisar rebuilt and the ditches redug, laying in stores of food and ammunition, ready to defend himself against the British, should they attempt to retake Kabul.[43] He also sent men to fortify with sangars and breastworks the narrowest points of the Tezin and Khord Kabul passes. He was only just in time.

On 22 July, after three months of waiting, Pollock and Nott finally received the orders they had been waiting for. Using a form of words that put all responsibility on the shoulders of the generals, Lord Ellenborough authorised the two men 'to withdraw via Kabul', if they so chose. He also ordered them 'to leave decisive proofs of the power of the British army'.[44] A race now began between the two generals to be the first to Kabul, though Nott had by far the furthest to go – some 300 miles against Pollock's 100.

'They have untied my hands and mark me, the grass shall not grow under my feet,' wrote an excited Nott to his daughters that evening. 'I sit writing here in full confidence that my beautiful, my noble regiments will give them a good licking.'[45]

Only one man was more delighted. 'I am so excited,' noted General Sale in a letter as soon as news of the advance had been announced, 'I can scarce write.'